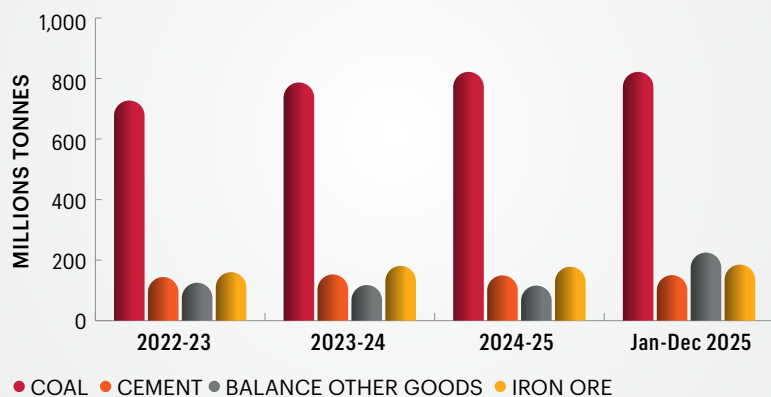


BIG LOAD

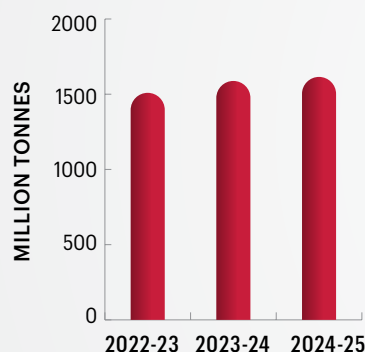
- Freight growth has remained sluggish over the past few years
- The Railways is targeting 3,000 MT freight a year by 2030



SOURCE INDIAN RAILWAYS

FREIGHT TRENDS

TONNES ORIGINATING



74 |

origin and destination points.

In 2025-26, freight revenue is estimated to be 5.1% lower than the budgeted target.

RATE RATIONALISATION

Declining revenue growth has been observed in the transport of cement and fertiliser by the Railways over the past few years. The introduction of the new policy was to make cement movement more competitive with that by roads.

As part of the Railways' reforms for cement transportation, Vaishnav unveiled the rationalisation of rates for bulk cement in containers. He said these reforms will bring down the cost of cement. Under the new policy, distance and weight slabs were removed, leading to a substantial reduction in cement transportation costs.

The policy enabled the movement of large volumes of cement in a single consignment and minimised packaging requirements while reducing material losses



“The biggest challenge is capex for infra creation for silos to store bulk cement and empty movement of wagons on return (trips)... [that] is wasting infrastructure”

LALIT CHANDRA TRIVEDI
FORMER GM, INDIAN RAILWAYS

from spillage by using cleaner transportation by road.

Additionally, the policy ensured faster turnaround times through mechanised loading and unloading, enhancing overall efficiency in cement logistics.

Garg says the policy can be termed successful only if it leads to a substantive increase in cement transported by rail. “This policy is applicable to bulk cement traffic moving in tank containers only. But the dead weight of 20 tonnes of the empty BLSS wagon is now also chargeable along with the traffic carried, because the rate charged is now based on per GTKM basis rather than NTKM basis. Hence, we will have to see how the cement industry finally reacts,” he says.

BLSS is a specialised freight wagon designed to transport intermodal containers and trailers. Gross tonne km (GTKM) looks at the total weight of locomotives and vehicles. Net tonne km (NTKM) is the transportation of a tonne of goods for a km.

Other challenges are looming, too. “The biggest challenge for this policy is capex for infrastructure creation for silos to store bulk cement and empty movement of